watched them with a mixture of admiration and envy, dying to make heroic dashes himself. No matter how intently he watched the siege, however, he kept one eye on the road to Lahore. Maham Anaka had gone to escort Hamida and the ladies to Mankot from that city. When he heard they were nearby, Akbar left the siege and went to meet them, to 'mutual rejoicings'.[53]

The harem brought good luck with them. In summer that year, Sikandar Suri gave up the fight and offered to surrender. Shamsuddin of Ghazni, Akbar's ataka, went into the fort to negotiate terms: all Sikandar wanted was to retire somewhere in the east. He sent 'money and goods' to bolster his case, though not to Akbar, nor even to Bairam, but to Pir Muhammad – some indication, perhaps, of Bairam's deputy's rising influence.[54] Then, on 24 July 1557, he gave up the keys to the fort and went away to Bihar. The east, Bihar and Bengal, would be the heart of vigorous Afghan resistance to Akbar's rule for years to come, but it would not feature Sikandar. He died in two years' time.

The Mughal camp should have been full of joy and bonhomie, the men reunited with their wives, their last real Suri challenger defeated. Instead, bad feeling filled the air.

Much of it was concentrated in Bairam Khan's tent, where Akbar's regent was laid up with a painful case of boils. Akbar doesn't seem to have been very concerned; he was busy fighting his elephants. One day, a particularly lively bout careened its way towards Bairam's tent – the trumpeting animals, the cheering spectators, exactly the kind of commotion designed to send an ill man into a rage.

What crime had he committed, Bairam railed to Maham Anaka, that Akbar had let 'furious elephants . . . loose against my tent?'[55]

Why would Bairam imagine that Akbar set the fight by his tent on purpose? Both Abul Fazl and the historian Nizamuddin say that gossips and troublemakers put the idea in the regent's head. Maham tried to 'quiet his disturbed mind', says Abul Fazl; Nizamuddin adds that Bairam was not to be soothed. In fact, he insisted that Maham convey his displeasure to Akbar.

Is it possible that Bairam was beginning to tire of the padishah's veil? Did he feel that Akbar was spending too much time fighting elephants and too little strategizing with Bairam? One day, some years later, Akbar would